office, and troops were put on alert to enter the financial district."[36]

As with most panics, the contagion spread from the Gold Exchange. Because of Gould's cornering of the market, stock prices dropped 20 percent, a variety of agricultural exports fell 50 percent in value, and the national economy was disrupted for several months.[37] Gould exited with a cool $11 million profit from the debacle, and scot-free from legal charges.[38] It is all too common that characters like Gould escape unscathed by the havoc they create, which then allows them to carry on with their machinations in other markets.

In the cryptoasset markets, characters toying with asset prices can often obfuscate their identity through the veil of the Internet, which unfortunately makes it even easier for them to escape. Often, they will target small and relatively unknown assets, which makes it important for the innovative investor who ventures into these smaller markets to pay particular attention to the details of those assets and the characters associated with them.

Beyond the Gold Exchange in 1869, examples of the cornering of commodities markets have continued to surface. In 1980, the Hunt brothers, who had been left billions by their wealthy oil-mogul father, attempted to corner the silver market. With inflation levels starting the year off at 14 percent, one of the highest levels on record,[39] the brothers believed silver would become a haven against inflation the way gold was, and they intended to own as much of it as they possibly could. Using the commodities markets and leverage, the